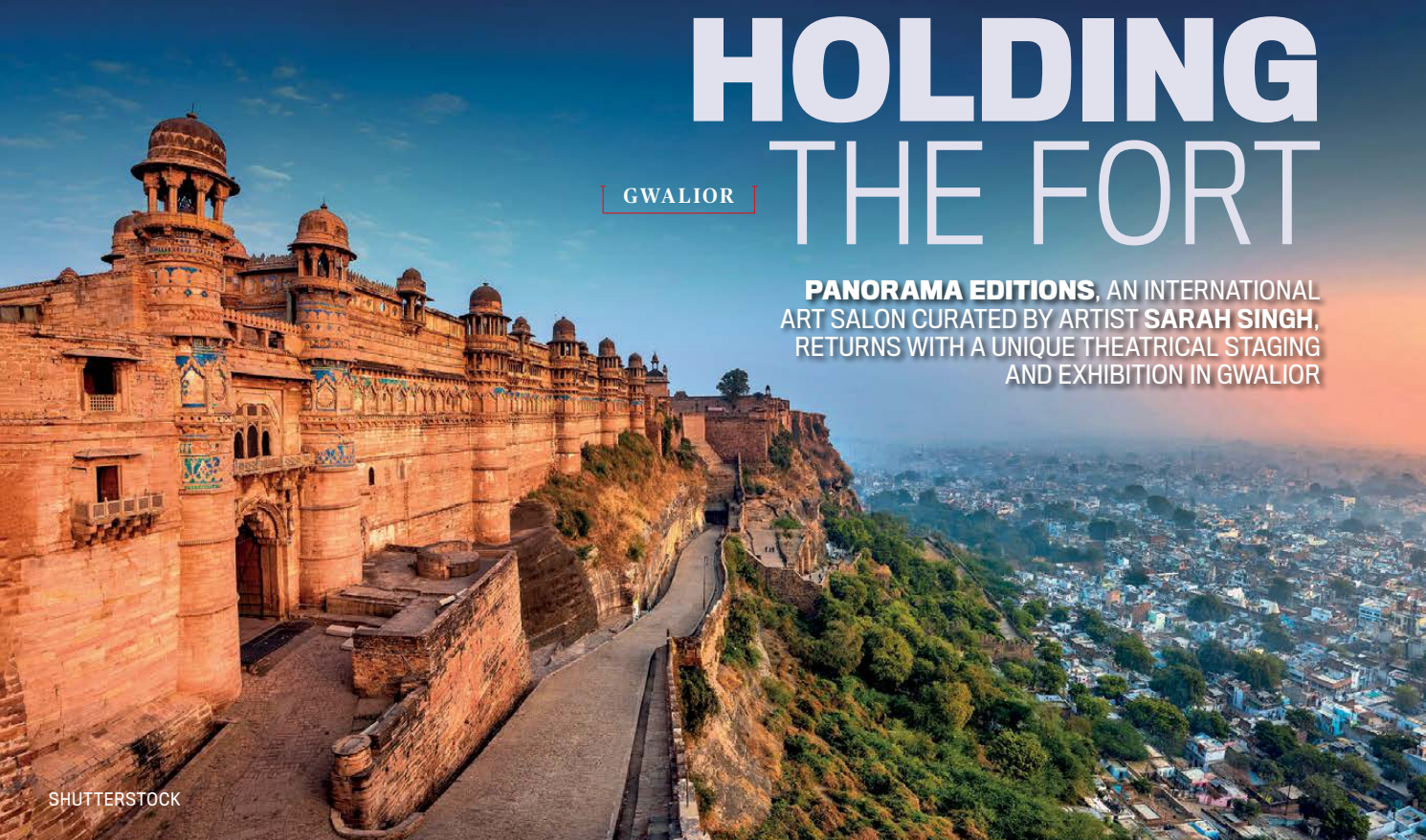
HOLDING THE FORT

GWALIOR

PANORAMA EDITIONS, AN INTERNATIONAL ART SALON CURATED BY ARTIST **SARAH SINGH**, RETURNS WITH A UNIQUE THEATRICAL STAGING AND EXHIBITION IN GWALIOR



SHUTTERSTOCK

This November, the historic Gwalior Fort will—for the first time—host a performance art event with more than 30 Indian and international artistes across various mediums such as classical music, dance and opera. A 'Street Cart Named Desire' is part of the fourth volume of Panorama Editions, an international art salon curated by Sarah Singh. Based in New Delhi and New York, Sarah is an award-winning artist and filmmaker whose multi-dimensional practice features moving images, text, photography, theatrical stagings, set and costume design, painting and drawing.

"This is not an Indian adaptation of the Tennessee Williams play, but a collage of performances that explores the theme of desire in different ways," says Sarah. "There's nothing explicit because that's not even interesting. Instead, desire can be explored through, say, the passion of flamenco or the absolute silence of a person sitting in one place," she adds. The im-



"THE ARCHITECTURE OF THE FORT IS ONE OF THE THEATRICAL ELEMENTS I AM BUILDING ON"

Sarah Singh
Artist and curator

provisational performance will open with Hindustani classical musicians from Gwalior and will feature, among others, flamenco dancers and guitarists from Spain, trombonists from Belgium, Greek opera singers, and a performance art piece by Vasco Araújo, a multi-disciplinary artist from Portugal.

As with the previous productions, all of which took place in historical forts, the Gwalior edition is specifically designed with the fortress as a backdrop. The performance (on November 16) will be held in a massive open ground that features an existing stone platform. "The architecture of the fort is one of the theatrical elements and I'm building just enough staging and framework through sound and light to create atmosphere in context of the fort," says Sarah. The performance uses minimum props and works largely with recycled, found and natural materials. As a corollary, an exhibition at the Jai Vilas Palace Museum will showcase artefacts and costumes from the theatrical staging. The first-of-its-kind exhibition is being mounted with the support of the Gwalior royal family and the museum's curatorial team, and will be on view for a week (November 17 onwards). Both the theatrical performance and exhibition are free and open to the public. The exhibition—with a few additional elements—will later travel to Purana Qila in Delhi and will be on view there from December 4-10.

The inaugural volume of Panorama Editions was presented in 2018 (as Panorama Punjab) at an 18th-century fort in Patiala, followed by a second edition at the Mehrangarh Fort in Jodhpur in 2019. After a pandemic-induced hiatus, the third edition was held last year at the grand Mool Sagar Palace inside Jaisalmer Fort. "The idea is to create low-impact interventions that bring these historic monuments to life through sophisticated, one-off performances. This offers a multi-layered experience where architecture is more than a superficial backdrop," says Sarah. ■

-Prachi Joshi